

Find contact details for Australian national animal health reference laboratories:

Policy for reference laboratories

The role of Australian national reference laboratories is designed to harmonise with the [World Organisation for Animal Health \(WOAH\) definitions of a reference laboratory](#) (with regional and international responsibilities):

- To function as a centre of expertise and to facilitate standardisation of techniques relevant to the specified disease(s).
- To store and distribute biological reference products and any other reagents used in the diagnosis and control of the specified disease(s).
- To develop new procedures for the diagnosis, control and exclusion testing of the specified disease(s).
- To gather, process, analyse and disseminate epidemiological data relevant to the specified disease(s).
- To participate in scientific and technical studies in collaboration with other laboratories or organisations.
- To publish and disseminate information on laboratory testing for the specified disease(s).
- To provide scientific and technical training for laboratory personnel in other Australian laboratories.

While not all reference laboratories may be able to provide all these functions, the list should act as a guide as to the expectations of a national reference laboratory.

Criteria for endorsement as an Australian national reference laboratory

To carry out the role requirements as outlined above, an Australian national reference laboratory is required to comply with these criteria:

- Employ scientific staff recognised as experts in the specified disease(s) and have an available range of diagnostic tests for the disease(s), including those not ordinarily available at other Australian laboratories.
- Where appropriate, be able to supply biological reference products and any other reagents used in laboratory testing for the specified disease(s).
- Conduct research to evaluate new laboratory tests for the specified disease(s) and encourage collaborative studies with other laboratories.
- Evaluate data submitted in support of the Animal Health Committee's (AHC) approval of new commercial test kits for existing laboratory tests, for the specified disease(s).
- Gather, process, analyse and disseminate data relevant to the laboratory aspects of the specified disease(s).
- Assist the Australian National Quality Assurance Program (ANQAP) to conduct proficiency testing where appropriate.

Access to reference laboratory services

Australian national reference laboratories will provide expertise and services to other Australian and New Zealand laboratories on a cost-recovery basis deemed appropriate by that laboratory.

Reporting requirements

All Australian national reference laboratories will submit a brief annual report of activities to the AHC through:

- the Subcommittee on Animal Health Laboratory Standards (SCAHLS) (if an Australian Animal Health Laboratory-based lab), or
- Animal Health Australia (AHA) (if a state-based lab).

This will include confirmation of expertise, data on testing levels, a summary of research including publications, and a record of training activities. The report will follow the same format as the annual WOAHS report. WOAHS reference laboratories which also serve as national reference laboratories may submit their annual WOAHS report to the AHC through SCAHLS rather than prepare an additional report.

In the event of a significant change in the ability of an Australian national reference laboratory to meet its requirements (e.g. the loss of designated 'expert'), the laboratory is required to advise the AHC through SCAHLS or AHA, as appropriate, of its intentions to retain or relinquish national reference laboratory status.

Our review process

The AHC will annually review the ability of each laboratory to meet the requirements of an Australian national reference laboratory.

When an Australian national reference laboratory fails to meet the requirements or relinquishes its reference laboratory status, the AHC, through SCAHLS or AHA, will require a statement justifying retention of reference laboratory status, or invite new tenders as appropriate.

If new tenders are called, all relevant laboratories will be invited to make submissions. When there is more than one submission for a given reference laboratory, the AHC, through SCAHLS or AHA, will assess each of the submissions on their merit and vote accordingly. All aspects of this review will occur 'in session'.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/agriculture-land/animal/health/laboratories/reference>